

The Laws That Govern Meditation

Go to Luke 16. We have been studying the laws that govern meditation in His Word.

Jesus was the Master Teacher. He said, "What I see My Father do, that I do, and what I hear Him say, that I say." Jesus never taught without teaching in total, entire subjects. He never went on to the next subject until He finished the one He was on.

We preachers and teachers have been guilty of taking verses out of context and making them say whatever we wanted. There is just one problem: faith only comes one way.

Faith cometh by hearing, and hearing by the word of God.

Faith does not come from my preconceived ideas, theology, or speculation. Faith comes from hearing what the Word of God says, not only about your victories, but also about your defeats.

When we destroy the imagery in the Word of God and make it say what we want, we fragment the seed.

People say, "If the Word of God says it, I believe it, and that settles it." No. This is not a democracy. God did not ask for your vote. It was true before you came along, and it will be true when there is a new heaven and a new earth. It is so whether you believe it or not.

Our job is to find it, not change it. When you find the substance of what He is saying, you have found faith.

Inside a seed is the diagramming and programming for the entire tree that is to come. Sometimes preachers take the seed and hit it with a hammer, breaking it into four pieces.

"Why did you do that, preacher?"

"I am going to get four times the harvest."

You will get nothing because you fragmented the image inside the Word and planted the pieces.

Jesus never taught without teaching entire subjects. If He were teaching on this pulpit, using words like a paintbrush, every Scripture would be a thought within itself, a stroke of the brush. But every stroke builds toward the completion of the entire picture.

When we lift one verse out of context and try to paint the picture around it, we make the ministry of the Holy Spirit as Teacher inside us very difficult.

Wouldn't it be better to meditate the entire picture, the entire outline, the entire subject, so the Holy Spirit can pick up the thoughts you do not understand and cause you to understand them by giving you the meaning of the whole subject?

For this reason, in meditating His Word, never take a verse out of context.

Remember, we are studying the method of meditation as much as the content of the subject.

Luke 16:1 says:

And he said also unto his disciples, There was a certain rich man...

Now go to verse 19:

There was a certain rich man...

Did Jesus change the subject? No. All the verses between are strokes of the brush, building toward the completion of the entire subject.

Back up to verse 18. Jesus was doing so well teaching on the stewardship of money until suddenly, for no apparent reason on the surface, He said:

Whosoever putteth away his wife, and marrieth another, committeth adultery:
And whosoever marrieth her that is put away from her husband committeth adultery.

Black and white. No ifs, buts, or "except for fornication" included here. Then, as though nothing happened, He goes right on to verse 19:

There was a certain rich man...

For years I meditated on this, wondering why in the world He left the cause of fornication out of this verse.

To find out, we have to back up to verse 13 and see that He did not change the subject.

Luke 16:13 says:

No servant can serve two masters...
Ye cannot serve God and mammon.

Mammon means temporary wealth pertaining to this life.

Verse 14 says:

And the Pharisees also, who were covetous, heard all these things: and they derided him.

Luke labeled them covetous Pharisees.

The word derided means they became so angry that they issued Him a challenge from the floor. I could see them in the Spirit, throats puffed up, faces red, screaming things such as, "You are a false prophet. You are a false teacher. You are of the devil. Abraham is our father. Moses gave us the Law. We do not even know what doctrine You are preaching."

These covetous Pharisees caused derision in His service. Jesus was the wrong One to do that to.

He answered:

Ye are they which justify yourselves before men; but God knoweth your hearts:
For that which is highly esteemed among men is abomination in the sight of God.

Because Jesus did not change the subject by verse 19, we can see what was highly esteemed among those covetous Pharisees:

There was a certain rich man, which was clothed in purple and fine linen, and fared sumptuously every day.

Fine linen, the best of everything, dining sumptuously every day. God does not care if you have those things, as long as they are sanctified. What makes what you have sanctified is when Jesus says, "Give alms of such things as ye have, and all things are clean unto you."

God does not care if you have those things. He cares if you have those things while stepping over the Lazaruses of the world.

How do I know what the Pharisees were screaming at Jesus from the crowd? Through the laws of meditation.

Two seemingly insignificant verses that I had passed over many times told me in detail what they were saying.

Luke 16:16-17 says:

The law and the prophets were until John: since that time the kingdom of God is preached, and every man presseth into it.
And it is easier for heaven and earth to pass, than one tittle of the law to fail.

The Pharisees were screaming, "We know who we are of. Abraham is our father. Moses gave us the Law. We do not know what doctrine You are preaching."

Jesus answered, "The Law and the prophets were until John. Since that time the Kingdom of God is preached. I have come on the scene in answer to your accusation that I am not of God. I am preaching the Kingdom, and every one of you Pharisees is going to have to press into it, because it is easier for heaven and earth to pass than one stroke of the Law to fail."

Those two verses show Jesus answering their derision. According to prophecy, the Law and prophets stopped at John. Jesus came and began preaching the Kingdom.

Then Jesus says:

Whosoever putteth away his wife, and marrieth another, committeth adultery...

For no apparent reason on the surface, He brings up marriage and divorce, then continues with the rich man and Lazarus. But He did not change the subject.

One night in Medford, around two in the morning, I had my feet on the desk and had meditated into the night. I drifted off, rolling this over in my spirit. In that place where your mind shuts down and becomes restful, the Holy Spirit took advantage of it and brought Romans 7 up in front of me. In a millisecond, He explained the entire revelation of Luke 16:18.

Jesus was talking about a change of covenants. Verses 16, 17, and 18 are one thought and were never meant to be separated.

The Law and prophets were until John. Since that time, the Kingdom is being preached. Every man must press into it. It is easier for heaven and earth to pass than one thing God said to fail.

Why mention marriage? Because God was married to Israel through the Law. For Jesus to put away the Law and preach another doctrine without fulfilling it would be like adultery.

God became a man for the purpose of suffering and dying in our place. When He died on the Cross, the Law died with Him. When the Law died with Him, it freed human beings to marry another, even Him who was raised from the dead.

If Israel stayed married to the Law after Jesus came, the offspring would be illegitimate, not born again. But because Jesus died and tasted death for every man, the Law died with Him and freed us to marry the risen Christ. Our union with Him produces born-again offspring, life unto God.

Romans 7:1 says:

Know ye not, brethren, (for I speak to them that know the law,) how that the law hath dominion over a man as long as he liveth?

The Pharisees knew the Law. Paul, a Pharisee of the Pharisees, memorized the Law for hours a day beginning at the age of three.

Romans 7 continues:

For the woman which hath an husband is bound by the law to her husband so long as he liveth;

But if the husband be dead, she is loosed from the law of her husband.

So then if, while her husband liveth, she be married to another man, she shall be called an adulteress:

But if her husband be dead, she is free from that law...

Then Paul says:

Wherefore, my brethren, ye also are become dead to the law by the body of Christ;

That ye should be married to another, even to him who is raised from the dead,

That we should bring forth fruit unto God.

Jesus was answering the Pharisees' accusation. He was saying, "You accuse Me of preaching false doctrine. But the Law and prophets were until John. I have come preaching the Kingdom. It is easier for heaven and earth to pass than one stroke of the Law to fail. God is married to Israel through the Law, and I am about to die. When I die, the Law will die with Me and free Israel to marry another, even Him raised from the dead."

Once I saw He was talking about a change of covenants, it freed me to understand the verses that include the clause elsewhere.

Would you like to learn to meditate in the hands of the Holy Spirit? Faith comes by hearing, and hearing by the Word of God.

Meditation will cause you to take a journey through the Word of God like a man exploring a new country for the first time. It will make you so pliable in the hands of the Holy Spirit that nothing God has for you will be withheld.

No matter who we are, what we are, or how successful we become, success in God depends on the transformation of our soul.

Many people were subjected to terrible things before they were born again, things that built strongholds into their souls: molestation, abandonment by someone they trusted, and other wounds.

When God took our stony heart out and gave us a new one, He gave Himself something to work with that makes the transformation of our soul possible: our new nature.

Without the new nature, there is no capacity to be transformed by His Word. With the new nature, there is no limit to how far we can go or what we can do.

Ezekiel 11:19-20 says:

And I will give them one heart, and I will put a new spirit within you;
And I will take the stony heart out of their flesh, and will give them an heart of flesh:
That they may walk in my statutes, and keep mine ordinances, and do them...

The reason we can walk in His Word and keep His commandments is that He has put a new spirit in us, become our God, and made us His people.

God wants to free us from major strongholds, but He does not stop there. He wants to free us in every area of life. He does not want you barely maintaining your emotions under the cares of life. He wants to fill your days with the things you love.

Third John 2 says:

Beloved, I wish above all things that thou mayest prosper and be in health, even as thy soul prospereth.

Transformation means a total shift from one thing to another. In our case, it refers to the soul: a complete change of character from bad to good, from weakness to strength, from turmoil to peace.

The best way for a person to be set free from poverty is when poverty comes looking and cannot find the same person living in susceptibility anymore.

There is no stronghold the Word of God cannot pull down and replace with an absolute change of character. The difference between two believers is not that God respects one person over another. It is that one has learned to meditate the Word of God in such a way that he is no longer bankrupt in character.

Psalm 1 says:

Blessed is the man that walketh not in the counsel of the ungodly,
Nor standeth in the way of sinners,
Nor sitteth in the seat of the scornful.
But his delight is in the law of the Lord; and in his law doth he meditate day and night.
And he shall be like a tree planted by the rivers of water...

Contained within the soul is the will, the right to make choices. I can choose to serve God or choose to serve the flesh.

No creature of God is forced to serve Him against his will, not angels and not men. It was not without great price that God left our will intact. This freedom to choose, even for the born-again believer, is the only thing that makes worship possible.

God did not reduce Satan to slavery when he exercised this option. Instead, God repaired the damage heaven sustained when Satan's free will led a third of the angels into rebellion. Adam's free will decision also damaged the human race.

God has put a high priority on your right to choose. If you choose His Word, God can take you into victory as far as others have taken themselves into destruction. But it will be your choice.

The soul has the ability to transform you to whatever you subject yourself to the most, whether good or bad.

That is why Psalm 1 talks about meditating the Word day and night. Even though we have a new nature, that new nature can be taken hostage by the soul if our will refuses counsel from the new nature and takes it from the flesh instead.

The more we subject ourselves to the flesh, the more we conform to it. The more we subject ourselves to the Word of God, the more we are transformed by it.

Romans 12:2 says:

Be not conformed to this world: but be ye transformed by the renewing of your mind...

The man we work with in Brazil is from Great Britain and came to Brazil fifty years ago as a teenager. Now he speaks fluent Portuguese. His accomplishments include getting evolution out of Brazil's textbooks and creation in, helping write Christian curriculum for the nation, starting and training professors for a law school, teaching English to Brazilians, and serving as a professor of political science and journalism.

When he talks about learning, I listen.

He said one of the worst ways to learn a new language is to intellectually follow a tape, trying to assimilate the language by mentally comparing one Portuguese word to an English word.

The best way is to be thrown into a Portuguese-speaking environment until you assimilate it. If you cannot do that, get a tape with nothing but Portuguese on it, including as many words as possible, and play it over and over. Your mind begins assimilating the sounds. Later, when association is made between Portuguese and English, pronunciation becomes automatic because half the labor has already been done.

I realized he was talking about the ability of the soul to transform a person into what he subjects himself to the most.

When a person only uses the intellect to learn a new language, he uses one attribute of the soul. But when he is thrown into a Portuguese-speaking environment, the whole soul kicks in: mind, will, intellect, and emotions. It assimilates an entire language.

What would happen if we learned to meditate the Word of God like that, to assimilate it and become everything God said we could be?

Suppose I wake up one day and decide I want to know more about giving and receiving, all the way to gospel entrepreneurship. I discover that heaven does not care to get involved with my finances until I care enough to get involved with heaven.

I do not have to be an evangelist, preacher, or teacher to gather souls to myself for later reward. I can invoke God into partnership with me so that we conduct business together and finance great soul-winning adventures with men of God.

God is not going to transform Himself to my way of thinking, so I have one option: transform myself to His way of thinking.

To do that, I go to the Word and find the thoughts of great men of God who blazed these trails before me. I assimilate what God taught them so I can walk the same path.

I do not believe Jesus ever spoke more highly of a man in these areas than He did of Solomon, and He did so in the light of God's willingness to meet our needs.

Matthew 6 says:

Consider the lilies of the field, how they grow; they toil not, neither do they spin:
And yet I say unto you, That even Solomon in all his glory was not arrayed like one of these.

Because Solomon was willing to judge righteously, help people, and intercede for the stranger outside Israel, God gave him such wisdom and wealth that he became a standard for all time of God's willingness to bless His people.

Solomon amassed extraordinary wealth. When he first took the throne from David, his first official act as king was to sacrifice a thousand burnt offerings to make sure nothing stood between him and God. At the dedication of the temple, he sacrificed 144,000 burnt offerings.

He also interceded for the stranger:

Moreover concerning the stranger, which is not of thy people Israel...
Then hear thou from the heavens, even from thy dwelling place, and do according to all that the stranger calleth to thee for;
That all people of the earth may know thy name...

This is a man God made rich because he subjected his soul to God and was taught how to operate with both God and man.

If Solomon left behind a record of everything God taught him, it would be worth assimilating. That is exactly what the book of Proverbs is: Solomon's legacy.

If I had a ministry of gospel entrepreneurship, wanted to increase my giving, or wanted wisdom for living and business, I would throw myself into an environment of wisdom. I would subject my soul to the wisdom of Solomon with the intention of assimilating Proverbs for the transformation of my soul.

I would get a small bag of pinto beans. Every time I read Proverbs from beginning to end, all thirty-one chapters, I would transfer one bean from one pile to the other until all fifty beans had changed piles.

I would do the first fifty readings without stopping to study individual verses. I would keep reading directly and deliberately, disciplining my mind to understand the thoughts in each verse. No matter how much I could read each day, I would keep going back until I had read the whole book fifty times from beginning to end.

Why? Because I am equipping my spirit with the complete outline, the whole embodiment of everything Solomon said about wisdom.

I cannot study day and night. I cannot read day and night. I cannot memorize the Word day and night. These things assist meditation; they do not replace it.

When I assimilate the whole outline of Proverbs by reading it fifty times, I take the first step toward equipping myself to meditate its wisdom day and night, anywhere, anytime, and under any circumstance.

A friend of mine named Augie was getting up to eight hundred people born again and filled with the Holy Ghost a month. The devil did not like it and sent an assignment against him to destroy him. This kind of spirit attacks the reasonings of a man.

The battle was something to behold. Satan tried to steal Augie's faith by challenging the core of what he believed. I knew some of the weapons Satan uses under these conditions: depression, hopelessness, and loss of reality.

I asked Augie, "What did you do?"

He answered, "I read the Word of God from Genesis to Revelation every six weeks for a year."

I asked, "How long did you read each day?"

He said, "Nonstop for six hours a day."

The devil was trying to destroy his reasonings, so Augie counteracted by passing everything God ever said about a human being through his spirit every six weeks for a year until his emotions stabilized.

While I was reading Proverbs fifty times, I would also get a continuous-play cassette player with automatic reverse and put Proverbs on tape so it could play over and over again.

If I could not get the whole book on one tape, so that each time I played it I received the whole outline from beginning to end, I would do whatever was necessary to get a deck that played two tapes in sequence until all thirty-one chapters passed through my spirit while I slept night after night.

One of the greatest times for assimilating information is in the early hours when you first wake up and lie there listening. Your soul is at full capacity, having cleared your mind through the night, and is ready to assimilate.

In the same way a person learns Portuguese by being thrown into a Portuguese-speaking environment, I would throw myself into a wisdom-speaking environment like the one Solomon lived in.

I would assimilate it, then get ready for the best God has to offer.

Let's worship God.